Region for a sustainable period, but the PLA Navy is familiarising itself with operating in these waters, and the Indian Ocean has been included in China's national defence strategy as a region that represents strategic challenges for Chinese interests.[104] China's naval presence here represents an expansion of the Chinese strategic *modus operandi*.

China is certainly not a newcomer on the Eurasian continent or in India's neighbourhood, but by launching the "Silk Road Economic Belt" and the "21st Century Maritime Silk Road" in 2013, formalised as official policy through a government white paper in 2015, China has lifted its engagement in the region to a new level. The BRI is primarily an economic initiative, but the size and implications of the project give it an important geopolitical feature. The BRI brings with it several geopolitical dimensions with relevance for Sino–Indian relations.

First, China hopes that the BRI will contribute to stabilising its most volatile western border in Tibet and Xinjiang through economic development and regional interconnectivity.[105] Second, China aims to tap into energy and mineral resources in Central and South Asia. China is the world's number-one importer of crude oil and minerals, with imports accounting for as much as one-third of China's gas demand. Chinese investments in cross-border pipelines into Central Asia as well as Iran and Pakistan are part of a diversification strategy and an insurance strategy that seeks to hedge against a potential disruption in China's seaborne petroleum supplies.[106]

Third, it is a stated goal of the BRI to connect China with the Indian Ocean through South Asia. China is constructing a network of roads, railways, and pipelines through Afghanistan, Pakistan, Myanmar, Nepal, and Bangladesh down to the Indian Ocean, enabling a diversification of the country's trade channels while diffusing the risks inherent to sea-lanes of communication (SLOCs). Chinese investments in deep-sea ports in Pakistan, Myanmar, and Sri Lanka are an